

Sentence Boundaries & Punctuation

Study Guide - Language & Editing

1. Learning goal

Recognize complete and incomplete clauses and use punctuation to separate, join, or introduce ideas correctly.

2. What this skill means

A complete sentence needs an independent clause. Fragments leave a dependent idea unfinished; run-ons join complete clauses without a legal boundary. Punctuation choices depend on clause structure first, not on where you happen to pause while reading.

3. Do not confuse it with

A comma alone cannot normally join two independent clauses. Use a period, semicolon, or comma + coordinating conjunction. A colon can introduce a list or explanation only after a complete clause.

4. How GED-style questions may ask it

Questions may ask you to repair a fragment or run-on, choose punctuation between clauses, or insert a colon, comma, semicolon, or apostrophe where structure requires it.

5. Repeatable method

- Find the subject and verb in each clause.
- Decide whether each clause can stand alone.
- If both are independent, use a legal boundary: period, semicolon, or comma + coordinator.
- If one clause is dependent, attach it to a complete clause.
- Use a colon only when the words before it form a complete clause that introduces what follows.

6. Worked example

The pilot ended on Friday; managers reviewed the results on Monday.

Question: Why can a semicolon join these parts?

Reasoning: Both sides are independent clauses that could stand as separate sentences, and their ideas are closely related.

Best answer: A semicolon is a valid boundary between the two complete related clauses.

7. Common traps

- Using a comma splice between two complete sentences.
- Treating a dependent clause beginning with because, although, or if as a complete sentence.
- Putting a colon after a verb or preposition when the preceding words are not a complete clause.

8. Diagnostic help

- If punctuation feels like guessing, mark each clause I for independent or D for dependent first.
- If you chose a comma between two I clauses, check whether a coordinating conjunction is also present.
- If you chose a colon, read only the words before it and ask whether they form a complete sentence.

Why this matters in ER: Sentence-boundary control is one of the fastest ways to make an ER clearer and easier to score for Standard English.

9. Quick check

The form asks for three details: the item, the location, and a contact method.

Why is the colon correct?

Check yourself: The words before the colon form a complete clause and announce the list that follows.